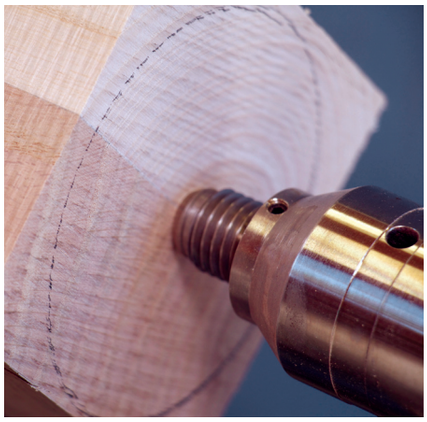
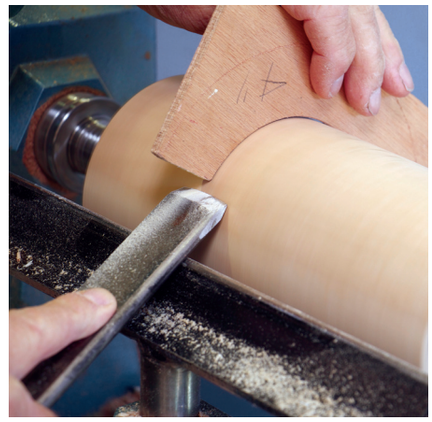
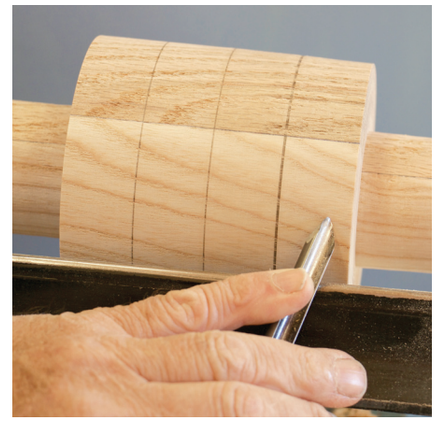


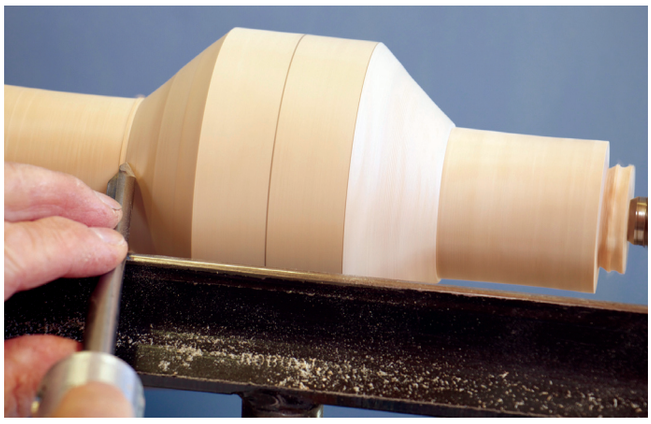
Draw a circle on each end grain to ensure the blank is mounted precisely



Use a skew chisel to turn an accurate cylinder



Divide the center section into for equal parts...



... and reduce the diameter of each end

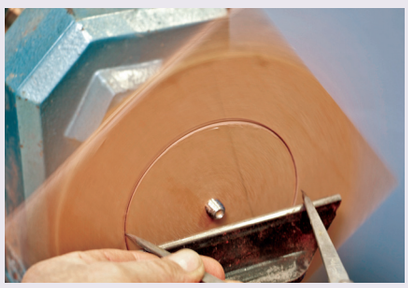
Turn a sphere between the two handles

1 Mount the blank between centers, ensuring that the drive and tail centers are in the center of the glue line. Check by holding a pencil against the end grain as you rotate the blank by hand. Turn a 4-in. (200mm) cylinder. I'm using a 4-in. (100mm) gauge to ensure an accurate cylinder.

2 Mark off an 8-in. (200mm) length in the middle of the blank and part in at right angles to the lathe axis to define that length. Next divide the 8 in. into four equal parts and reduce the diameter of each end to 2 in. (50mm). In the top photo on the facing page the handles are sized and the central portion is divided into four equal parts in preparation for turning a sphere between the handles. The spindle gouge is poised to cut the first of the facets; you can see them completed in the middle photo on the facing page.

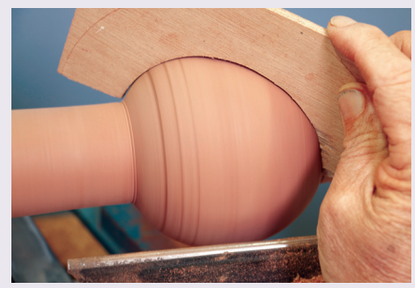
3 Turn away the waste between the outer lines and the top corner where the handles meet the emerging sphere. Then round over the corners, working away from the centerline and checking the curve as you go. To create a spherical surface right to the handles, you'll need to increase the length of the handles.

TURN A GAUGE FOR SPHERES



Lay out the required gauge diameter on a square of scrap plywood or MDF

A ⅜ in. (10mm) fingernail-ground gouge cuts through plywood



A gauge held against spinning wood will burnish high spots

Mount a square of scrap plywood or MDF on a screw chuck and lay out the required diameter. Then use a ⅜-in. (10mm) fingernail-ground gouge to cut through the plywood. As you cut through, the outer ring will usually end up spinning on your gouge. Cut this in half to use as a gauge. Burnish marks will indicate high points on the spheres you are working on.

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